



**Even-steven:** England's Ben Stokes and India's Shubman Gill shake hands as they pose with the Anderson–Tendulkar Trophy after the gripping series ended in a draw on the final day of the fifth Test at The Kia Oval in London. PTI

grew into the job.

At Lord's, his leadership was on full display when he had a heated exchange with Zak Crawley and Ben Duckett. As the angry young captain told the England batters to "grow some ba\*\*s", he was no longer merely reacting — he was making a statement. Gill led from the front, letting his bat speak with 754 runs in 10 innings, and passed that aggression on to his teammates.

No wonder Pant could bat with a broken foot or Mohammed Siraj could ignore workload limits to bowl 185.3 overs — 1,113 deliveries — in the series. Siraj finished as the leading wicket-taker with 23 wickets, bowling with both heart and skill.

Moving away from the Ravi Shastri or Rahul Dravid era, when four or five specialist bowlers were the norm, the team management opted for batters who could bowl. In the absence of Kohli and Rohit, the aim was to add batting depth, which proved effective as Washington Sundar, batting lower down, scored fifties and a century to keep India competitive. While the coach and captain hinted that this could be the future template, bowling coach Morne Morkel admitted the move was primarily to maintain balance. "That was part of the conversation before every selection so far. We just felt leading into the Test match that going with the extra batter was going to be

important," Morkel said.

The approach worked.

In the fast bowling department, even though Bumrah played just three matches, he regularly spoke to Siraj, Akash Deep and Prasidh Krishna in training. At Old Trafford, he was seen in animated huddles with the quicks. In Bumrah's absence, Siraj took on that mentoring role. "Whenever he (Bumrah) plays, I support him, and in his absence, I know I have the ability to take the wickets," Siraj said. At The Oval, with England inching closer to the target, Siraj repeatedly walked up to Prasidh and Akash between deliveries, calming nerves with a hand on the shoulder and encouraging words.